

weaknesses of Shivam Dube, Harshit Rana might be the best option at eight. His ability to bowl the 5–6 m length and swing the ball up front, coupled with his dipping, cutting slower ones, provides India the flexibility to use Jasprit Bumrah in the last 10 overs. Also, Harshit can serve as a handy number eight, tonking a few bonus sixes at the end once in three games.

Hardik, Arshdeep and Harshit can take care of the PowerPlay, with all three of them likely to take early wickets with their ability to get lateral movement. Arshdeep and Bumrah can operate in the slog overs, with the former executing his swinging yorkers and steep bouncers. The middle overs can be controlled with a combination of Harshit and Hardik hammering the hard lengths, and Varun and Axar (pic, right), with an over or two of Bumrah thrown in. This combination gives the captain six bona fide bowling options, with seven and a half batters at the ideal positions to



K. R. DEEPAK

maximise their match-ups. Tilak Varma and Hardik can stabilise the innings in the event of a collapse, while Axar plays disruptor and Rinku provides late-order ballast.

Both Tilak Varma and Axar have had injury scares recently. In case Tilak misses out, Ishan Kishan or Shreyas Iyer are ready replacements. While Kishan is weak against pace, he is a better hitter of in-spin, which makes him an ideal pairing with Suryakumar at four. Iyer has shown massive improvements in his handling of pace, but playing two right-handers at three and four might reduce the possible runs India can score off the spinners. Replacing Axar, on the other hand, might be close to impossible for India. It is tough to find a slow left-arm all-rounder who hits spin well, but with the injury to Washington Sundar being reported as serious, Riyan Parag might be slotted in as a middle-order hitter who can deliver two overs of defensive spin.

The author is a physicist based in France. He worked as the consultant analyst for the India Men's team from 2022 to 2024.

My ideal India XI



Ishan Kishan (wk)



Abishek Sharma



Tilak Varma



Axar Patel



Hardik Pandya



Rinku Singh



Harshit Rana



Arshdeep Singh



Jasprit Bumrah



Varun Chakaravathy



Suryakumar Yadav (captain)